was hit again, and this time he did not get up. The company JCO was also killed, leaving Havildar Gurmukh Singh in command.

By that time, the Sikhs had been reduced to eighteen men and a few other non-combatants. Once again, the Chinese attack died down, as they too decided to wait for the light of dawn and additional reinforcements to renew their attack. While the Chinese numbers continued to swell on the riverbank, the commanding officer of 3/3 GR failed to push any troops through to help Gurmukh Singh and his surviving men. Even though the Chinese had laid an ambush on the track, a determined attempt could have been made.

As visibility started to improve at dawn on 16 November, the men at The Ladders could hear the posts above them fighting ferociously, but owing to the nature of the terrain, on the western side they were blindsided completely. On the other hand, Major Chand's Gorkhas had a grandstand view of developments on the river below and the east bank. Chinese troops in rubber boats were still crossing the Lohit in large numbers and were surging up the steep bank to attack Gurmukh Singh's remaining men. From his vantage point, Major Chand could see the Sikhs fighting desperately. At around 7.30 a.m., a small party led by an artillery officer, Second Lieutenant P. S. Bhandari, suddenly appeared at High Plateau and began directing the Indian guns positioned on the rear flank of Dakota Hill. The guns joined the battle with deadly effect. However, by then, the Chinese were mopping up the surviving troops and Bhandari was also killed. By 8 a.m. it was all over for Delta Company—High Plateau had fallen.

Strangely enough, the Chinese did not press on towards Dong Plateau. Instead, they began to physically haul RCL guns up to High Plateau, from where they started firing at The Ladders across the river. The defences in the rock wall that had so far been immune to artillery fire were now repeatedly hit. The bunkers crumbled and the falling dust blinded the Gorkhas. All they could do was move to the forward location that was also intermittently attacked through the day.

THE WITHDRAWAL

On the morning of 16 November, the corps commander, Kaul, and GOC 2 Mountain Division, Mohinder Pathania, had been in Walong, sitting in the Brigade HQ where Brigadier Rawlley and his brigade major, Ashok Handoo, were trying to control the battle. Kaul described the atmosphere in